The Adoption Papers

By Jackie Kay

NOTE: This is a poem in 3 voices . . . each should be portrayed with a unique mannerisms, posture and voice. – Speakers are from Scotland, so some lines are written in that dialect.

- ***Red: Adoptive Mother (a white woman from Scotland)***
- ***Black: Daughter (a dark-skinned, bi-racial child -- adopted)***
- ***Green: Birth Mother (a white woman from Scotland who fell in love with a black man from Nigeria)***

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I always wanted to give birth
do that incredible natural thing
that women do - I nearly broke down
when I heard we couldn't,
and then my man said
well there's always adoption
(we didn't have test tubes and the rest then)
even in the early sixties there was something scandalous
about adopting, telling the world your secret failure
bringing up an alien child,
who knew what it would turn out to be

I was pulled out with forceps
left a gash down my left cheek
four months inside a glass cot

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but she came faithful
from Glasgow to Edinburgh
and peered through the glass
I must have felt somebody willing me to survive;
she would not pick another baby

I still have the baby photograph
I keep it in my bottom drawer

She is twenty-six today
my hair is grey

The skin around my neck is wrinkling does she
imagine me this way

INTRODUCTION

One in five children waiting to be adopted is from an ethnic minority and for them the wait is three times as long as for white children. Twenty per cent never find new homes.

Bi-racial author, Jackie Kay was born in 1961 to a white nurse from the Highlands and a Nigerian student studying agriculture at Aberdeen University. Her father returned to Nigeria, leaving her 19-year-old mother with a difficult decision to make: keep the child or put her up for adoption. Kay was ultimately adopted by a white Scottish couple.

Kay's ability to address the personal issue of adoption as well as the added issue of race is eloquent, truthful and moving. The Adoption Papers by Jackie Kay

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I say to the man at the desk
I'd like my original birth certificate
Do you have any idea what your name was?
Close, close he laughs. *Well what was it?*

So slow as torture he discloses bit by bit
my mother's name, my original name
the hospital I was born in, the time I came.

Outside Edinburgh is soaked in sunshine
I talk to myself walking past the castle.
So, so, so, I was a midnight baby after all.

I am nineteen
my whole life is changing

On the first night
I see her shuttered eyes in my dreams

I cannot pretend she's never been
my stitches pull and threaten to snap

my own body a witness
leaking blood to sheets, milk to shirts

On the second night
I'll suffocate her with a feather pillow

Bury her under a weeping willow
Or take her far out to sea

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and watch her tiny eight-pound body
sink to shells and reshape herself.

So much the better than her body
encased in glass like a museum piece

On the third night
I toss I did not go through these months

for you to die on me now
on the third night I lie

willing life into her
breathing air all the way down the corridor

to the glass cot

The first agency we went to
didn't want us on their lists,
we didn't live close enough to a church
nor were we church-goers
(though we kept quiet about being communists).
The second told us
we weren't high enough earners.
The third liked us
but they had a five-year waiting list.
I spent six months trying not to look
at swings nor the front of supermarket trolleys,
not to think this kid I've wanted could be five.
The fourth agency was full up.
The fifth said yes but again no babies.

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Just as we were going out the door
I said oh you know we don't mind the colour.
Just like that, the waiting was over.

This morning a slim manilla envelope arrives
postmarked Edinburgh: one piece of paper
I have now been able to look up your microfiche
(as this is all the records kept nowadays).
From your mother's letters, the following
information:
Your mother was nineteen when she had you.
You weighed eight pounds four ounces.
She liked hockey. She worked in Aberdeen
as a waitress. She was five foot eight inches.

My eyes snatch pieces of news
headlines strung out on a line:
MOTHER DROWNS BABY IN THE CLYDE

November
The social worker phoned,
our baby is a girl but not healthy
she won't pass the doctor's test
until she's well. The adoption papers
can't be signed. I put the phone down.
I felt all hot. Don't get overwrought.
What does she expect? I'm not a mother
until I've signed that piece of paper.

The rhythm of the train carries me
over the frigid earth

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the constant chug a comforter
a rocking cradle.
Maybe the words lie
across my forehead
headline in thin ink
MOTHER GIVES BABY AWAY

December
We drove through to Edinburgh,
I was that excited the forty miles
seemed a lifetime. What do you think she'll
look like? I don't know my man says. I could tell
he was as nervous as me. On the way back his face
was one long smile even although
he didn't get inside. Only me.
I wore a mask but she didn't seem to mind
I told her *any day now my darling any day.*

Nobody would ever guess.
I had no other choice
Anyway it's best for her,
My name signed on a dotted line.

March
Our baby has passed.
We can pick her up in two days.
Two days for Christ's sake,
could they not have given us a bit more notice?

I must stop it. Put it out my mind.
There is no use going over and over.

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I'm glad she's got a home to go to.

When I got home
I went out into the garden -
the frost bit my old brown boots –
and dug a hole the size of my baby
and buried the clothes I'd bought anyway.
A week later I stood at my window
and saw the ground move and swell
the promise of a crop,
that's when she started crying.
I gave her a service then, sang
Ye banks and braes, planted
a bush of roses, read the Book of Job,
cursed myself digging a pit for my baby
sprinkling ash from the grate.

Today I ring the counselling agency in Edinburgh.
Can you start to trace through marriage
certificates?
It will take three weeks what do you expect from it.
If she wants to meet me that's fine if she doesn't
that is also fine

That night I turn it through till dawn
a few genes, blood, a birth.
All this bother, certificates, papers.
It is all so long ago. Does it matter?

She took me when I'd nowhere to go
my mammy is the best mammy in the world OK.

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Now when people say 'ah but
it's not like having your own child though is it',
I say of course it is, what else is it?
she's my child, I have told her stories
wept at her losses, laughed at her pleasures,
she is mine.

Maybe that's why I don't like
all this talk about her being black,
I brought her up as my own
as I would any other child
colour matters to the nutters;
but she says my daughter says
it matters to her

To be honest I hardly ever think about it
except if something happens, you know
daft talk about darkies. Racialism.
Mothers ringing my bell with their kids
crying *You tell. You tell. You tell.*
- No. You tell your little girl to stop calling
my little girl names and I'll tell my little girl
to stop giving your little girl a doing.

We're practising for the school show
I'm trying to do the Cha Cha and the Black Bottom
but I can't get the steps right
my right foot's left and my left foot's right
my teacher shouts from the bottom
of the class Come on, show

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us what you can do I thought
you people had it in your blood.
My skin is hot as burning coal
like that time she said Darkies are like coal
in front of the whole class - my blood
what does she mean? I thought

she'd stopped all that after the last time
my dad talked to her on parents' night
the other kids are all right till she starts;
my feet step out of time, my heart starts
to miss beats like when I can't sleep at night –
What Is In My Blood? The bell rings, it is time.

Sometimes it is hard to know what to say
that will comfort. Us two in the armchair;
me holding her breath, 'they're ignorant
let's have some tea and cake, forget them'.

Olubayo was the colour of peat
when we walked out heads turned
like horses, folk stood like trees
their eyes fixed on us - it made me
burn, that hot glare; my hand
would sweat down to his bone.
Finally, alone, we'd melt
nothing, nothing would matter
He never saw her. I looked for him in her;
for a second it was as if he was there
in that glass cot looking back through her.

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Now my secret is the hush of heavy curtains
drawn.
I dread strange handwriting
sometimes jump when the phone rings,
she is all of nineteen and legally able.
At night I lie practising my lines
but 'sorry' never seems large enough
nor 'I can't see you, yes, I'll send a
photograph.'
I have had my grandmother's Highland number
for four months-now burning a hole in my filofax.

Something this morning gives me courage
to close the kitchen door and dial.

My grandmother's voice sounds much younger
'I used to work ages ago with your daughter

Elizabeth, do you have her present address?'
Sorry, she says, *No, but one of the girls*

will have it. She gives me another Highland number
wishing me luck. *What did you say your name was?*

Thirty minutes later my mother's sister
asks lots of questions - *Where did you work?*

How long ago was that? What age are you?
Forty I lie. *For a minute I thought ...*

But if you're forty, you can't be.

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I know she knows. The game's a bogey.

Actually I'm 26. *I thought so love.*
I thought it was you. Mam knew too.

She just rang to warn me you'd ring.
How are you? How's your life been?

I'll give her yours. She'll write.
I'm sure you understand. I do. I do.

The Meeting Dream . . .

If I picture it like this it hurts less
We are both shy
though our eyes are not,
they pierce below skin.
We are not as we imagined:
I am smaller, fatter, darker
I am taller, thinner
and I'd always imagined her hair dark brown
not grey. I can see my chin in hers
that is all, though no doubt
my mum will say, when she looks at the photo,
she's your double she really is.

There is no sentiment in this living-room,
a plain wood table and a few books.
We don't cuddle or even shake hands
though we smile sudden as a fire blazing
then die down.

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Her hands play with her wedding-ring,
I've started smoking again.
We don't ask big questions even later by the shore.
We walk slow, tentative as crabs
No, so what have you been doing the past 26 years.
Just what are you working at, stuff like that.

Ages later I pick up a speckled stone
and hurl it into the sea,
is this how you imagined it to be?
I never imagined it.
Oh. I hear the muffled splash.
It would have driven me mad imagining,
26 years is a long time.

Inside once more I sip hot tea
notice one wood-framed photo.
The air is as old as the sea.
I stare at her chin till she makes me look down.
Her hands are awkward as rocks.
My eyes are stones washed over and over.

If I picture it like this it hurts less

One dream cuts another open like a gutted fish
nothing is what it was;
she is too many imaginings to be flesh and blood.
There is nothing left to say.
Neither of us mentions meeting again.

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**[but we never did meet . . . and that's OK . . . maybe she'll write . . . someday] *Transition – not in the original poem*

It's surprising how often it crops
up; that he or she didn't know anything about it
and now who is he or she really
do they love who they thought they loved
et cetera. You've got the picture.
Mine knew. As soon as possible
I always told her, if you ever want to,
I won't mind. I wasn't trying to be big
about it - if that was me, that's how I'd be.
Curiosity. It's natural. Origins.
That kind of thing. See me and her
there is no mother and daughter more similar.
We're on the wavelength so we are.
Right away I know if she's upset.
And vice versa. Closer than blood.
Thicker than water. Me and my daughter.

I wrapped her up in purple wrapping paper
And threw her down the old well near here.
Years - she's been in my drawer
Faded now, she's not a baby any more
Still pitch dark. It didn't matter.
I know every bend. I've no more terror.

Her sister said she'd write me a letter.
In the morning I'm awake with the birds
waiting for the crash of the letter box
then the soft thud of words on the matt.

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I lie there, duvet round my shoulders
fantasising the colour of her paper
whether she'll underline First Class
or have a large circle over her 'i's.

She took me when I'd nowhere to go
my mammy is the best mammy in the world OK.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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